Chapter 13

Building Approval-Based Workflow Automation in a Zoho Creator Application

1. Aim

To build and test an approval-based workflow that routes submitted requests to an authorized reviewer and records the decision.

2. Objectives

- Map the stages and roles in an approval process.
- Configure a workflow or approval mechanism supported by the application plan.
- Define approval, rejection, and notification behavior.
- Test normal and exceptional cases and maintain a traceable status.

3. Requirements

A Zoho Creator application with a request form, suitable user permissions, and access to workflow or approval features.

4. Theory

Workflow automation applies rules when an event occurs, such as form submission or a status change. An approval process commonly moves through Submitted, Pending Approval, Approved, or Rejected states. The workflow can notify a reviewer, prevent unauthorized edits, and store the decision and comments. The exact configuration depends on available platform features and plan. Good workflow design defines who may approve, what happens when a request is rejected, how duplicate or incomplete requests are handled, and how decisions can be audited.

5. Procedure

1. Create or select a request form with fields for requester, details, status, reviewer, and comments.
2. Draw the process from submission to review and final decision.
3. Configure the supported workflow or approval feature to route a new request to the correct reviewer.
4. Set status updates and notifications for approval or rejection.
5. Restrict decision fields so only authorized reviewers can update them.
6. Test approved, rejected, incomplete, and unauthorized-action scenarios.
7. Review the record history or available audit information to confirm that decisions are traceable.

6. Case Study and Analysis

A department receives requests to purchase laboratory components. The previous process relies on email messages and verbal follow-up, making it difficult to know whether a request is awaiting review or has been approved. The automated workflow begins when a user submits a complete request. The record receives a Pending Approval status and the designated reviewer is notified. The reviewer approves or rejects the request and may add a comment. The status changes accordingly, and the requester receives a notification. In testing, the team checks that a requester cannot approve their own request unless policy explicitly permits it, that rejected requests retain the reason, and that incomplete submissions do not bypass required fields. The team also considers what should happen when the reviewer is unavailable, such as reassignment or escalation according to departmental policy. Automation improves consistency and visibility, but it should not replace clear approval limits or financial controls. Permissions and notification rules must be tested before the workflow is used for real purchases.

7. Result / Discussion

The workflow design provides a traceable route from submission through review to a final decision, with status updates and notifications.

8. Conclusion

Approval automation can reduce follow-up effort and improve accountability. Clear roles, exception handling, and access control are necessary for a dependable workflow.

9. Precautions / Best Practices

- Use fictional or non-sensitive test data during practice.
- Verify settings and results before using the application or configuration in a real environment.
- Record observations clearly and follow the platform's current documentation, security, and access-control guidance.